The Indian government's efforts to reach out to Beijing preceded those of Washington. American officials were aware of Delhi's desire to seek a modus vivendi with Beijing. Dinesh Singh told Nixon that Gandhi, too, believed that China should be brought into "the world community." Subsequently, Jung even sought to discuss "cooperation with China" with Kissinger.[22]

Delhi's efforts to mitigate the China threat were partly motivated by the desire to reduce its overall dependence on external actors. The Indian government was more confident than before, but it was still dependent on external assurance on the security front, especially since it had not yet developed its nuclear option, and indigenous defense production could not meet demand. The reliability of assurances from both Moscow and Washington, however, was questionable, given increasing Soviet-Pakistani interaction and the memory of American neutrality in 1965. A rapprochement with China could reduce India's need for these external assurances.

There was another reason: as Haksar noted, continued Chinese hostility "distort[ed] the country's economy by obliging [India] to maintain a high level of defence spending."[23] Rapprochement could thus also free up funds for India's development needs at what Gandhi called a "time of travail," when India was economically vulnerable and the premier politically so.[24]

Thus, despite little or no response from Beijing to earlier trial balloons, in January 1969, Gandhi publicly signaled readiness for a dialogue with China without preconditions in the hope that this would eventually lead to a settlement of the border dispute. A month later, she again indicated that India was open to talking to China.[25] She maintained this stance even when China rejected her offer as hypocritical. Foreign Minister Singh reiterated that India was open to negotiating with China, as long as Beijing showed India some respect. The government also publicly played down reports of Chinese border ultimatums to India in April. Privately, Delhi instructed Indian troops at the border to be prepared, but also careful not to take any action that could be misconstrued as provocative. Even as Sino-Soviet relations deteriorated over the spring and India received reports of China moving some of its nuclear installations from Xinjiang to Tibet, the foreign ministry reiterated publicly that India was keeping the door open to talks with China. Later in the year, Gandhi made it a point to send greetings to